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God's Purpose in Your Pain

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God's Purpose in Your Pain

Today's Reading: John 21:15-19

Hearing God's Voice for Today:

"Peter was grieved because he said to him a third time, 'Do you love me?' and he said to him, 'Lord you know everything; you know that I love you.' Jesus said to him, 'Feed my sheep.'"

* * * * *

Jesus was doing spiritual heart surgery on Peter. He wanted Peter to know of his forgiveness for his denials. He desired for Peter to know that his love conquers all sin. He hungered for Peter's heart to believe he still had a great plan for his life.

Three times, Jesus asked Peter if he loved him. Three times, Peter responded in the affirmative. But the third time that Jesus asked this question, Peter showed great angst. Exasperated, he said, "Lord, you know that I love you." Jesus smiled inwardly, for Peter's heart was now prepared to receive Jesus' purpose for his life..

How did Jesus know Peter was ready? He knew because Peter had not only admitted his love for the Lord, but he also realized that Jesus knew everything. Peter trusted Jesus with all his being. That was essential— and the Lord knew Peter's heart belonged totally to him.

Jesus then commissioned Peter again to feed his sheep. He knew Peter would. He knew this disciple would take the message of forgiveness and faith that he had personally experienced and faithfully impart it to others.

That was Jesus' plan for Peter. In the upper room, Satan had asked permission to sift Peter like wheat.³¹ As with Job, the Lord granted permission. There is nothing Satan can do to any of his followers unless God permits it. He may be the devil, but he is God's devil. He is on a leash. He is not all-powerful.

Though this sifting would be exceedingly painful for Peter, it was Jesus' will for him. The pain would burn away his arrogance and impetuosity. It would prepare him for the plan Jesus had for him to be a primary pillar in the church.

It would also give Peter insights into essential eternal truths. His two New Testament letters were written primarily to a persecuted people. Because he had gone through his own deep pain, suffering, and disappointment, he could express the power of God's grace to those who needed great comfort and encouragement. The words he wrote would be life-giving words based on his own personal experience.

And the readers of his letters would have their faith profoundly encouraged.

There is purpose in your pain as well. The Lord keeps track of all your sorrows. He collects your tears in a bottle and records each one.³² No tear that you shed is ever useless. No sigh in your soul goes unheeded.

How might God be using your troubles? The comfort you have received from him, you'll be able to give to others who are walking through a similar experience.³³ Like Peter, you'll be able to give to them the grace that you yourself received.

God causes all things to work together for good—even your painful problems.

If you don't believe that's true, read what Peter wrote in his two New Testament letters.

He will assure you there that it is true.

[from "*Hearing the Voice of God*" by Pastor David Chadwick, *Moments of Hope Church, Charlotte, NC*]